

Chapter 77-5

//

After the brief embrace, Xu Qingzhu let go of her and only then answered her question: "The household auntie¹ has already gone to rest. No one can open the door, so you wouldn't be able to get in."

"How long did you wait?" Liang Shi followed her inside.

Xu Qingzhu answered perfunctorily: "Not long."

As soon as Liang Shi got close to her, she felt the chill. While Xu Qingzhu wasn't paying attention, she placed her hand on her neck—it was so cold that Liang Shi shivered.

This sudden approach made Xu Qingzhu instinctively step back, her whole body shrinking slightly. She glanced at Liang Shi, "Teacher Liang, why are you launching a sneak attack?"

Her tone had returned to its usual manner, without any of the fragility seen in the video call.

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "Why are you so cold?"

"It's cold outside." Xu Qingzhu said: "Standing for a while makes you cold."

Liang Shi said: "Then you should have waited for me to arrive before coming downstairs. I would have called you."

"Liar." Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly, "If I hadn't been waiting outside for you, you'd probably be on your way driving back by now."

Liang Shi: "....."

A flicker of uncertainty passed through her eyes, but she quickly said: "How could that be?"

Xu Qingzhu smiled without saying anything.

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu brought her back to her room, then leaned against the headboard, her whole body burrowing into the blanket, before asking: "What did you want to tell me?"

Liang Shi stood up and asked her: "Is there hot water?"

Xu Qingzhu said: "In the kitchen downstairs, same setup as at home."

"Then wait a moment." After saying this, Liang Shi took her cup and went out. The cup still had half a glass of cold water in it.

Xu Qingzhu stared at her departing figure in a daze.

Not long after, Liang Shi returned with a tray carrying a glass of water and a glass of milk.

Liang Shi handed the hot milk to Xu Qingzhu and said with a serious expression: "Do you know why you had a nightmare?"

Xu Qingzhu: "Hm?"

"You didn't drink milk." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Oh."

Liang Shi held the hot water in her hands, her whole body warming up. She sat on the edge of the bed, but didn't really have anything to say.

It was rather awkward.

After a while, Xu Qingzhu lightly kicked her with the top of her foot through the blanket: "What did you want to talk about?"

Liang Shi paused briefly, "Just asking about the moving situation."

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu teased her: "Didn't Zhao Xuning already tell you? Don't ask what you shouldn't ask."

"Then this is something I should ask." Liang Shi said: "It's where you'll be living in the future. What if you move in and feel uncomfortable?"

Xu Qingzhu tucked her loose hair behind her ear: "If I'm uncomfortable, I'll just put up with it. What else can I do?"

Liang Shi looked at her, lightly pressing her lips together: "Are you not planning to stay for very long?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "Huh?"

"Never mind." Liang Shi realized she had said too much. "Hurry up and drink. Rest after you finish. You still have work tomorrow."

There was a hint of giving up on herself in her tone.

Xu Qingzhu didn't pay it any mind and lowered her head to slowly drink the milk.

Liang Shi sat on the edge of her bed, drinking the warm water half-heartedly.

She wasn't actually thirsty, and drinking too much water before bed wasn't good anyway, so she only drank half before putting down the cup. Xu Qingzhu quickly finished her glass of milk and placed her cup together with Liang Shi's.

One transparent, one milky white—placed together, they somehow matched.

Liang Shi put the cups on the other side of the room, then stood awkwardly in the room for a while.

Finally unable to help herself, she got up to leave: "You should rest."

She stood in front of Xu Qingzhu's bed, looked down to confirm she was alright, and then reminded her: "Set your alarm. Remember to eat breakfast."

Xu Qingzhu tilted her head up, unexpectedly meeting her gaze.

That cool, clear voice rang out in the room, but the ending rose, carrying an indescribable meaning: "Where are you going?"

"Home." Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "You came all the way here just to heat up a glass of milk for me?"

Liang Shi: ".....And to discuss things."

As long as a clumsy excuse wasn't exposed, it could keep being used.

This was her last bit of stubbornness.

Xu Qingzhu chuckled softly: "You're leaving after we're done talking?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "You have work tomorrow. Go to sleep early."

Xu Qingzhu stared at her, the corners of her mouth continuously upturned, as if something worth being happy about had happened.

Liang Shi didn't ask. She was busy being annoyed with herself.

She had noticed that this kind of thing had been happening more and more frequently lately.

Being annoyed with herself, yet not knowing what she was annoyed about.

In any case, her mood was somewhat low.

She planned to think about it after going home tonight, and calmly digest all the bad emotions by herself.

Just as she was about to turn and leave, Xu Qingzhu reached out and grabbed her wrist. Those cool fingers gently brushed over the blood vessels on her wrist—right where she could feel her pulse.

Her heartbeat suddenly quickened, but Xu Qingzhu's fingertips stopped right there.

"Thump— Thump—"

Liang Shi wanted to pull her hand away, but Xu Qingzhu held on extremely tight. She tugged on Liang Shi's arm again and said gently: "Teacher Liang, stay."

Liang Shi turned back in surprise, meeting Xu Qingzhu's eyes once more.

Those eyes were clear and transparent, yet carried an indescribable sadness.

Xu Qingzhu said: "Chat with me for a while."

Footnotes:

¹ "Household auntie" (阿姨, āyí) - In Chinese households, particularly wealthy ones, this refers to a domestic helper or housekeeper. The term "auntie" is used as a respectful form of address for older women who work in service roles, regardless of actual family relation.